

WE BUILT IT FOR \$61.

Tokenomics is not the price of tokens. It is **which model does which job**, and **how many times you pay to re-read the same context**. Here is one week of it, itemised.

QTY	DESCRIPTION	AMOUNT
320 M	TOKENS DELIVERED at frontier list, uncached	\$1,695.80
	LESS: PROMPT CACHE REUSE the same context, not bought twice	-\$1,121.97
6,541	LESS: WORK ROUTED OFF THE METER local model and flat-fee tiers	-\$512.70
	TOTAL DUE	\$61.13



Nobody gave us a discount. Every credit on this bill is an architecture decision.

TWO LEVERS. NEITHER ONE IS A DISCOUNT.

01 THE RIGHT MODEL FOR THE JOB

Writing a function against a written spec is not the same task as deciding whether that function is correct. We price them the same anyway – everything goes to the best model we have, out of habit.

Sort the work first. **Judgment goes to the frontier model. Volume goes to a small model on your own hardware.** The router is the product decision; the model is not.

NEVER LEFT THE LAPTOP

of every call in the build

85%

02 PAY ONCE FOR THE SAME CONTEXT

An agent re-reads its whole world on *every single turn* – the spec, the code, the conversation so far. Priced fresh each time, that repetition is most of what appears on the invoice.

Cached, those identical tokens cost **a tenth**. It is the largest lever in this deck and the least glamorous: no vendor call, no model change. **Ask your team their cache hit rate.** Most cannot answer.

SAVED BY CACHING

on one week of this build

\$1,122

A PHOTO OF THE SKY IN.

RIGHT ASCENSION

230.668166°

15h22m40.36s

DECLINATION

11.035501°

+11d02m07.80s

ROLL

332.28°

SOLVED FOV

11.422°

MATCHES

47

SOLVE TIME

1.8 ms

RMSE

8.56 px

P90 ERROR

11.85 px

MAX ERROR

16.95 px

FALSE-MATCH PROB

1.01e-87

Real output. No GPS, no timestamp, no metadata – just pixels.

READOUT	VALUE
SOLVE TIME	1.8 ms
STARS MATCHED	47
PATTERN DATABASE	1.01 M

Astronomy software that works out where a telescope was aimed – from the pixels alone. It is how a satellite finds itself when it is lost in space.

It is real, and it is benchmarked. Rust, gRPC service, web UI, runs on Raspberry-Pi-class hardware, and it passes a parity test against an independent Python reference it did not write.

That matters for one reason: the bill I am about to show you bought working software, not a demo. The product is the receipt – not the subject.

ALL OF IT RAN ON THIS LAPTOP.

COMPONENT	WHAT IT IS	COST
MACBOOK PRO M5 Pro • 48 GB unified	Already owned	SUNK
LLAMA.CPP qwen3.6-27b, 4-bit, on Metal	Writes the code	ELECTRICITY
LITELLM the switchboard, on :4000	Routes every call	OPEN SOURCE
CLAUDE CODE fired on the sonnet alias → local	Does the work	\$0
RALPH-GRIND.SH a bash loop in a tmux session	Runs unattended	40 LINES
ME, WATCHING IT a frontier model, on the meter	Supervises	\$60.80

The trick is the switchboard. Claude Code asks for a model by name and never learns what answered.

SCHEDULE B • WHAT ACTUALLY ANSWERS
“SONNET” the tool's default workhorse → LOCAL QWEN
“HAIKU” background and summarisation traffic → LOCAL QWEN
“OPUS” the one I chose to keep on the meter → REAL, PAID

That is a config file, not a rewrite. Nothing upstream changed – the same commands, the same tool, the same repo.

So the build itself was free. Every row above the red one cost nothing to run. The meter only ever ran when I opened a session to check on it.

NOTHING IN THE LOOP COSTS MONEY.

PLAN.MD

Written once, by a human. The spec, the task list, and the definition of done – the only durable state, which is why the loop survives a restart.

THE ONLY METERED THING

\$60.80

Me, on a frontier model, **watching it run.** 5.5% of the calls – and 99.5% of the bill.

SCHEDULE A · REPEATS PER TASK

01

PICK THE NEXT TASK

fresh agent, empty context

\$0

02

LOCAL MODEL WRITES IT

qwen3.6–27b · on this Mac

\$0

03

JUDGE REVIEWS IT

glm-5.2 · a different model family

⌵ FAIL → back to 02 · retry ≤ 3×, then park for a human

04

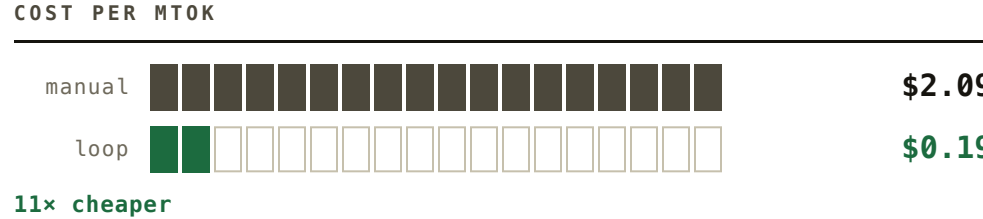
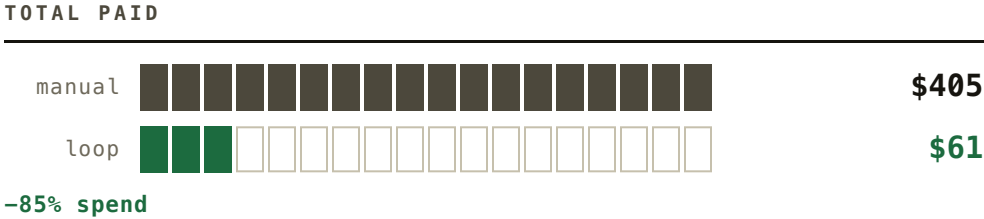
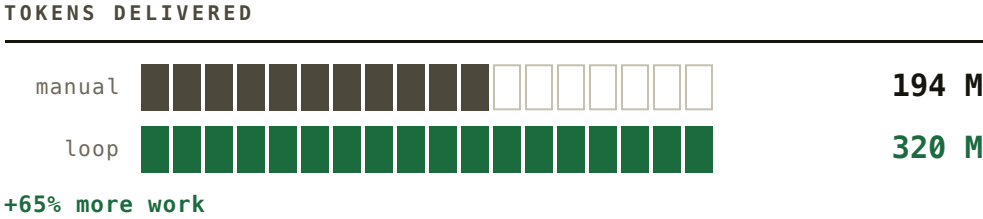
GATES RUN, THEN COMMIT

compiler · tests · parity oracle

\$0

⌵ Next task – agent exits, context resets, cost stays flat

**ONE WEEK BY HAND. ONE
WEEK ON THE LOOP.**



Honest but not perfect. The manual week included spec authoring and architecture – different work, not just slower coding. The unit-cost trend is the claim; a task-for-task comparison would be tighter.

Against the counterfactual: those same 320 million tokens run entirely on the frontier model would have cost **\$574**. Without caching on top of that, **\$1,696**.

85% NEVER LEFT THE BUILDING.

Here is where every call in that week actually went – and what each tier cost.

Note the shape. **Volume and spend point in opposite directions.** The tier doing almost all the work is the tier that bills nothing; the tier doing 5.5% of the calls is essentially the entire invoice.

That is what routing buys you, and it is why the interesting question is never “*which model is best*” – it is **which of these rows does this particular task belong in.**

WHERE IT RAN	CALLS	COST
LOCAL on this Mac · writes the code	5,880	ELECTRICITY
FLAT-FEE CLOUD the judge · already paid for	654	\$0 MARGINAL
FRONTIER human oversight · 5.5% of calls	381	\$60.80

At frontier rates the judge alone would have been **\$160** – taking the build from \$61 to \$221.

MOST OF WHAT YOU PAY FOR IS RE-READING.

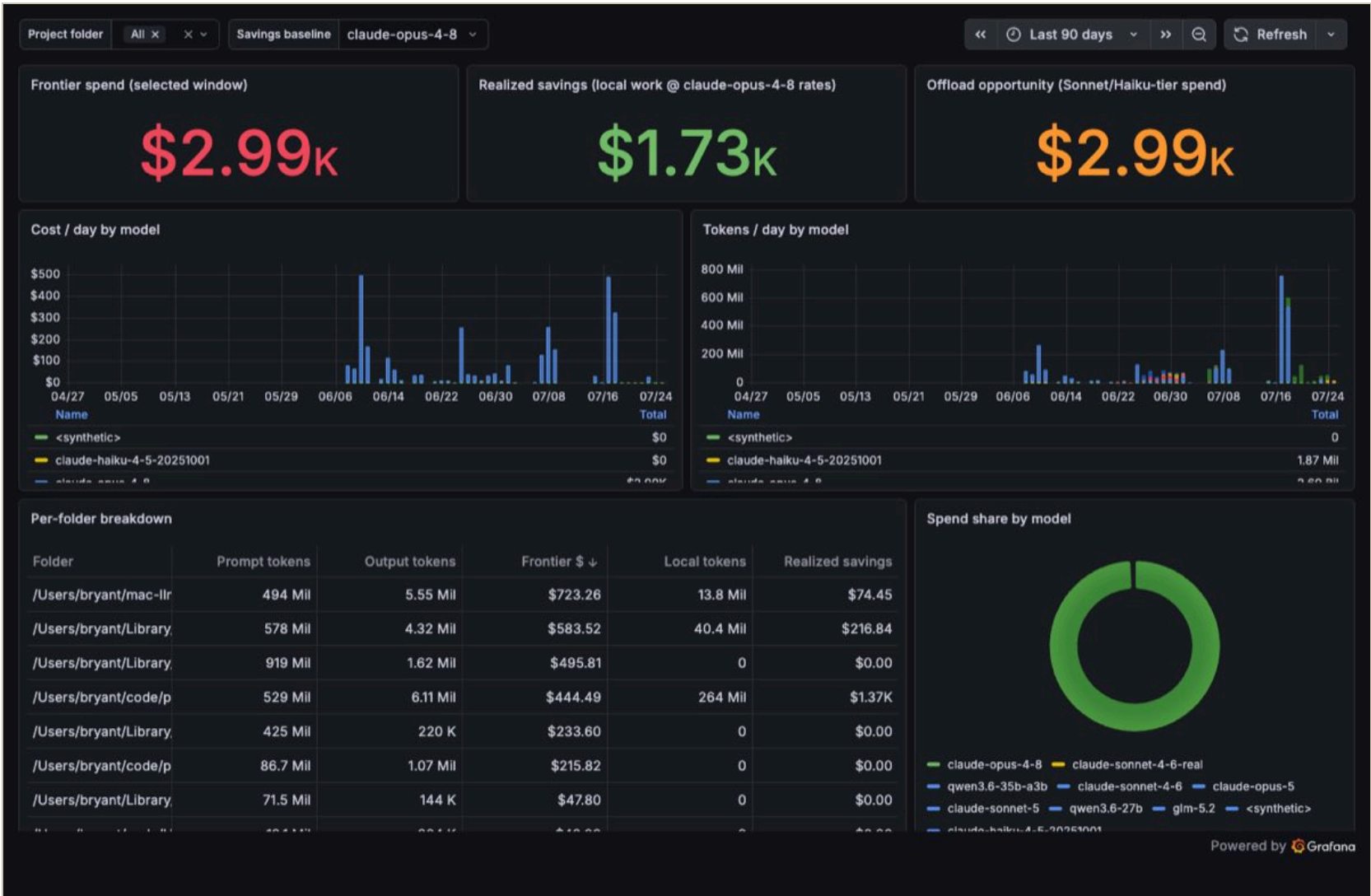
Lever two, and the largest number in this deck – larger than every routing decision combined.

Read the three rows as one sentence. Run the obvious way, this build was **\$1,696**. Turning on caching alone took **\$1,122** off it. Routing then took most of the rest.

Which is the uncomfortable part: **the biggest lever required no model change at all**. It is a header, a stable prompt prefix, and someone bothering to check the hit rate. Pure engineering, and nobody gets promoted for it.

RUN THE OBVIOUS WAY \$1,696 No caching, no routing
SAVED BY CACHING ALONE -\$1,122 One config change. No model change.
THEN ROUTING DID THE REST \$61 What we actually paid

YOU CAN'T MANAGE WHAT YOU CAN'T SEE.



Live board, **all projects** – filter to plate-solver in the room. Alt-tab and drive it; this is the backup.

THE DISTRIBUTION

Volume sits on the cheap tier; spend concentrates in a handful of expensive calls. You cannot find those without this board.

THE TREND

Realized savings, tracked continuously – the counterfactual as a live number, not something reconstructed after the fact for a slide.

Tokens is an input metric. Cost per unit of delivered work is a business metric. Only one of them belongs on an executive's dashboard.

THREE MOVES, NONE ABOUT PRICING.

01 ROUTE BY SIZE, NOT BY HABIT

Most tasks don't need the frontier model, and the ones that do are identifiable before you dispatch them. A router is cheaper than a better model.

02 CACHE AGGRESSIVELY

The single biggest lever here, and the one nobody measures. Ask your team what their cache hit rate is. Most cannot answer.

03 BOUND THE CONTEXT

Long-lived agents get expensive because context compounds. Ending the process is a cost control – a fresh agent per task keeps the bill flat as the project grows.

The whole talk in one line: we did not get cheaper by finding cheaper tokens. We got cheaper by changing where the work runs, and how often we pay for the same context.

THREE THINGS TO ARGUE ABOUT.

- WHERE ARE YOU PAYING FRONTIER PRICES FOR WORK A SMALL MODEL COULD DO?
- DO YOU KNOW YOUR CACHE HIT RATE? IT IS USUALLY THE BIGGEST LEVER, AND ALMOST NOBODY MEASURES IT.
- DO YOU KNOW YOUR COST PER DELIVERED THING — OR JUST YOUR MONTHLY BILL?

Backup follows: the two expensive failure modes, and provenance for every number in this deck.

THE FIRST THREE DAYS COST MORE.

PHASE	TOKENS	PAID
-------	--------	------

JUN 9–11 · BY HAND

19% local

194 M

\$405

JUN 25 – JUL 1 · LOOP

85% local

320 M

\$61

June 10 alone was \$313 – one day, 1,744 calls, five times the entire loop week. That day is what paid for the architecture on slide three.

THE THREE FIXES, ALL IN V1 HISTORY

f207947 Jun 10 – move the judge off the frontier tier, and trim the orchestrator's context. The first cost fix was a context fix.

ef871a9 Jun 27 – offline mode with a deferred judge queue, so review batches instead of blocking a paid seat.

0af42c4 Jun 29 – a --judge-model flag to route review to a separate, cheaper account entirely.

And the loop caught real defects for free. 1885bba · Jun 28 – the judge failed the SV2 task on step ordering, and the loop opened its own follow-up rather than merging it or stalling. That review cost nothing marginal; catching it at frontier prices would not have.

WHERE EVERY NUMBER CAME FROM.

CLAIM	VALUE	SOURCE
Scope – ralph-loop window	Jun 25 – Jul 1, 2026	first loop task → 8932c62 workspace integration; 8f32748 post-impl archive
Repo lineage	bryantharpe/plate-solver	tag v1-original = 185128e (absent on tharpeslalom)
Corroborating cutoff	104de07 · Jun 30	tharpeslalom/main tip = merge-base; repo stops where the run stops
Total calls in window	6,922	usage_events, folder = /Users/bryant/code/plate-solver
Tokens delivered	320.0 M	SUM(input + output + cache_creation + cache_read)
Actually paid	\$61.13	usage_events × model_prices
Ran on a local model	84.9% of calls	model_prices.is_local
Same workload, all Opus	\$573.83	counterfactual at \$5/\$25/\$6.25/\$0.50 per MTok
Saved by caching	\$1,121.97	cache_read_tokens × (input rate – cache-read rate)
Frontier calls / spend	381 · \$60.80	claude-opus-4-8 – human monitoring
Judge model	glm-5.2 · 654 calls	routed via grind --judge-model (0af42c4)
Local author model	qwen3.6-27b	litellm/config.yaml – sonnet alias remapped to local
Manual phase	\$405.05 · 194.0 M	Jun 9–11, same folder, 18.7% local
Unit cost	\$2.09 → \$0.19 /MTok	paid ÷ tokens, per phase
Solve time · stars matched	1.8 ms · 47	ps-web UI screenshot, docs/screenshots/

Not counted: work after Jul 1 moved to a home DGX under a different orchestrator and is not in this database. Every figure above is re-runnable live against the Postgres store behind the Grafana board.